

English 501

Lec # 21 History of English Language

Short Notes

Middle to Modern English (1500–1650)

1. Shift from Middle to Modern English:

- **Long vowels:** Underwent major pronunciation changes.
 - **Short vowels:** Mostly stable; notable changes:
 - 'a' returned to an Old English-like sound (*at*, *apple*).
 - 'u' changed from the sound in *full* to *but* (*cut*, *sun*).
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The Great Vowel Shift

- Occurred from the 15th to 18th centuries.
 - **Long vowels:** Pronunciation shifted with tongue raised and mouth closed.
 - Example: *a* in *father* became *a* in *name*.
 - Spelling remained unchanged, leading to a mismatch with pronunciation.
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Weakening of Unaccented Vowels

- Vowels in unstressed syllables weakened or disappeared over time.
 - French-origin words also experienced this change.
 - Informal speech and dialects still reflect weakened vowels.
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Changing Socio-Historical Context (1500–1650)

- **Key factors influencing language change:**
 - **Printing Press:** Introduced by William Caxton (1476), standardized English.
 - **Education & Communication:** Expanded rapidly, increasing language usage.
 - **Specialized Knowledge:** New vocabulary emerged with new discoveries.
 - **Self-Consciousness:** Awareness about language use grew.
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Language Change During the Renaissance

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- **Language Policy:**
 - Discussions on standardizing English began in the 16th century.
 - Focus on spelling improvements and vocabulary enrichment.
 - **Shift from Latin to English:**
 - English replaced Latin for academic and professional writing.
 - New English words were created for specialized knowledge.
 - **Self-Consciousness:**
 - Individual: People refined personal language use.
 - Public: Society debated language rules and policies.
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Key Points for MCQs:

1. **Great Vowel Shift** happened between the 15th and 18th centuries, changing long vowels.
2. The **printing press**, introduced by William Caxton in 1476, helped standardize English.
3. **Latin** declined as a scholarly language, replaced by English during the Renaissance.
4. **Unaccented vowels** weakened or disappeared, especially in unstressed syllables.
5. New vocabulary emerged due to **growth of knowledge** and reduced use of Latin.

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